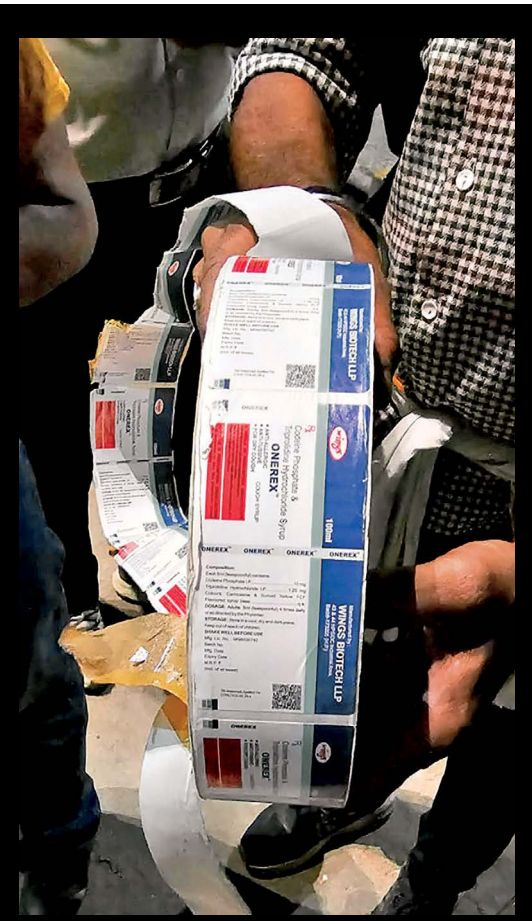
CODEINE CAPITAL

THE VINDHYA REGION HAS SEEN HUGE HAULS OF ILLICIT COUGH SYRUPS MADE OF CODEINE. THE DRUG SCOURGE HAS RAVAGED THE AREA

By RAHUL NORONHA *in Rewa*





154,547

bottles of codeine-based cough syrup seized (Jan. 1, '25-May 31, '26)

As dusk settles in on Rewa's *kabaadi mohalla* (scrap colony) and its ragged residents slowly drift home from work, groups begin to gather in the shadows. Walking up to one such, we ask a woman standing in an unlit spot for six bottles of cough syrup. She stares back, wary that the strangers may be police decoys. "*Kal aana* (Come tomorrow) with Rs 3,000," she says and walks away, not committing to anything. The *kabaadi* colony's notoriety has spread in town, it is well-known as a haven for cough syrup peddlers.

Welcome to Rewa, formerly the capital of Vindhya Pradesh (it was merged into the larger state of Madhya Pradesh in 1956), and now, according to authorities, the state's 'codeine capital'. Rewa city, along with the surrounding districts of Satna, Sidhi, Singrauli, Mauganj and Maihar—collectively called the Vindhya region—has seen a massive spurt in cough syrup abuse and addiction cases in the past few years. Cough syrups with codeine phosphate in them are most in demand, given the high the substance ensures. Consumption of around 100 ml of a codeine-based cough syrup can give a high spanning 24-36 hours.

Between January 1, 2025, and May 31, 2026, the police confiscated 84,547 bottles of the syrups (worth Rs 1.01 crore) from the six districts of Rewa division. Some 685 people have been arrested under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act. Last year, 2,000-odd poly substance addicts sought treatment at Rewa's Shyam Shah Medical College, most of whom abused cough syrup too. The problem is so acute the state police now has a dedicated 'Operation Prahaar', to bring the syrup tsunami under control. In late May, in the single biggest seizure perhaps in central India, a special task force (STF) seized 73,000 bottles in a raid in capital Bhopal. Again, the consignment was bound for the Vindhya region.

So, why is cough syrup abuse so big in the Vindhya region? "A key reason is the unregulated supply, made easier by the large border the region shares with Uttar Pradesh," says Gaurav Rajput, IG,